ART

Culture in the Capital

India's first **biennale** dedicated to art, architecture and design is on at the Red Fort in New Delhi





INDIA PICTURE

The first-ever India Art, Architecture and Design Biennale (IAADB) has begun at the Red Fort in New Delhi on December 8. The week-long Biennale (**to be held until December 15**) has been organised by the Ministry of Culture. A host of Indian and international artists, curators, designers and architects are slated to deliver keynote addresses. There will be public art installations, a dedicated art bazaar as well as a series of exhibits mounted by students. To showcase the students' work separately, the Lalit Kala Akademi is also hosting a Student Biennale concurrently from the 9th of December. Pavilions set up as a part of the IAADB shall remain in place until March 31, 2024.

During a curtain-raiser press conference, Meenakshi Lekhi, minister of state for culture and external affairs, said, "The biennale showcases a diverse range, including traditional artisans, contemporary designers, curators, and thought leaders. It is an innovative initiative to celebrate the rich tapestry of our country's artistic heritage, spanning ancient, modern, contemporary and tech-driven art, architecture and design."

The seven days of the Biennale have been planned according to daily themes, with curated walks planned by experts on each of these days. Day One ('Pravesh') is dedicated to the history and architecture of doors and gateways and the visitors' walk will be led by Aditya Arya. Day Two ('Bagh-E-Bahar') is all about the gardens of India, and Anjchita B. Nair will lead the visitors' walk. The rest of the days are earmarked for temples ('Sthyapatya'), baolis ('Sampravah'), post-Independence architecture ('Vismaya'), folk art ('Deshaj') and women's contribution to architecture ('Samatva'), respectively.

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Apart from these attractions, the ministry of culture also invited submissions from artists, curators et al on social media. This prompted 560 queries and 260 submissions, out of which a total of 150 submissions have been selected for display at the biennale.

Mugdha Sinha, joint secretary, ministry of culture, says, "The response to our call for submissions has been extremely positive. We are confident that the biennale will become a much-loved event and we want to extend this beyond Delhi too. We hope that practitioners from all of these fields display their skills at the IAADB and also help us bring Indian traditions to a wider platform and on the world stage." Sinha adds that as far as the ministry is concerned, one of the additional objectives of the biennale is to provide Indian artists, curators and other practitioners a kind of warm-up event before the Venice Biennale. ■

Aditya Mani Jha